

tic T20 leagues—are they your subordinates, rivals or equals?

A. Nation vs nation cricket has been the lifeblood throughout the cricket-playing world, and I don't see that changing. The current proliferation of T20 leagues is an indication of the success of T20 cricket, and it's attractiveness to the subscribers and sponsors.

Q. But does the ICC see them as subordinates, rivals or equals?

A. I think we have international cricket on the one hand and domestic cricket on the other and we have a system for approving and recognising domestic cricket.

Q. Lalit Modi has not asked for an IPL window in the ICC calendar but won't it solve problems?

A. I think Lalit Modi is right not to ask for a window. It will be difficult to provide a window not because IPL is successful, but there could be other highly successful domestic leagues—are we going to provide windows for all of them?

Q. But that means players will have to pick and choose?

A. I think really talented young cricketers will want to play for their countries. The value of a player in his domestic league, if he's played for his country with distinction, will be much higher.

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on with the Deccan Chargers for \$1.35 million per year, he could turn out for the Queensland Bulls squad in Australia next season, with the Johannesburg-based Highveld Lions franchise interested in signing him for limited-overs cricket. Symonds said recently, "Now I have to make up my mind how much cricket I want to play and who for."

Where Symonds has gone, many more will go in the future, particularly if wages from the international game do not match those of privately-funded franchises. For six months of cricket,

Twenty20 says an IPL 'window', "would be ideal because then players don't have to juggle international and domestic commitments".

Beyond scheduling, this could even be a survival issue for international though Morgan doesn't quite see it that way. Gilbert says a future with T20 free agents is "inevitable". "If administrators don't find a window for the IPL, the players will find one themselves." Making it difficult for the T20 leagues, "is asking for confrontation—programmers have to sit down and be

THE IPL HAS BEEN A GAME-CHANGER FOR CRICKET



MAKING IT DIFFICULT FOR THE TWENTY20 DOMESTIC LEAGUES IS ASKING FOR CONFRONTATION—PROGRAMMERS HAVE TO SIT DOWN AND BE SENSIBLE.

three current Indian teams has never been shy of saying in private that he cannot be too fussed with Test cricket.

Still unconvinced? Think of two words: Andrew Symonds. The Australian sent home in disgrace from the Ashes tour has lost his national contract. In the past, he would have spent the rest of the career as a first-class struggler. Now he is set to become the world's first freelance T20 multi-millionaire, unencumbered by rules and the protocol of Test tradition. Already signed

Symonds can hope to clean up close to \$1.5 million. Offer the same conditions and half that salary to the average pro today and signatures on contracts will materialise faster than Harry Potter can say *Riddikulus!*

ICC President David Morgan (*see interview*) is unmoved by the scare stories. He says fixed slots in the calendar for T20 leagues are out of the question. Stuart Robertson, commercial director of Hampshire cricket and the man credited with inventing

sensible". The two sets of programmers are not in the same room, let alone on the same page. Robertson does not think of T20 as a monster he has created that could actually derail the world game. "I can't see players giving up the chance to play international cricket... I can't see any domestic event being as big as the IPL."

Perhaps not, but put all the T20 leagues together and ask every pro to pick between rich club or glorious country. What would you choose? ■